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Budget Smartphones

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It has been amazing to see the rate at which the market of budget smartphones has grown. Adding a higher value for your money to smartphones has resulted in numerous smartphone-makers flooding retailer store shelves with a whole host of hand-held devices. These include features that were once kept neatly reserved for the most expensive ones. Eight-core processors, multiple gigabytes of memory, increasing amount of built-in storage space and higher megapixel counts in cell-phone cameras have brought

the power to your hands – your right to claim the pocket-sized device that would, five years ago, come in the form factor of, say, a decent notebook.

The price-sensitive segment also happens to be one that is seeing an increasingly high rate of growth in terms of user base, number of new devices, and the advancement in the nature of components that are being included in the handsets being introduced.

Sensing that the time was apt, we decided to take a look at some of the best smartphones that you can purchase within a budget of ₹13,000, and choose the best device in terms of price, performance and my personal



Asus Zenfone 2 Laser

pick out of the nine devices that we put into the pit.

ASUS ZENFONE 2 LASER

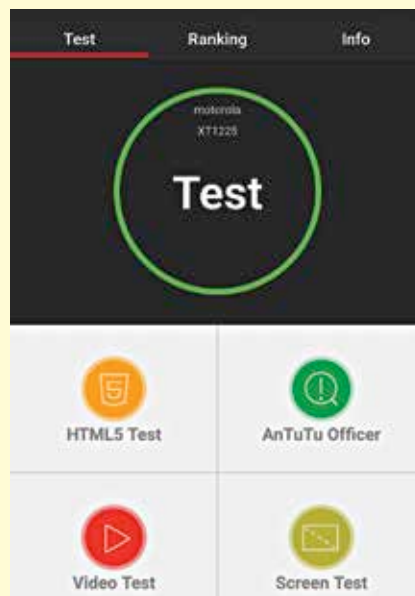
The base proposition of ASUS' extensive Zenfone 2 lineup came across as a competent performer for its price, with the unique proposition of it being the cheapest smartphone providing a laser-assisted autofocus camera among its repertoire. Bordering on being tagged 'boring' in terms of design, the Asus Zenfone 2 Laser is really not a 'new' smartphone. Instead, it is a stripped-down version of the original Zenfone 2 design, running on cheaper hardware. That's all there is to it.

HOW WE TESTED

The first and foremost idea was to find out the device which performed the best, given the restricted price bracket. Within ₹13,000, it was okay if low-light imaging was not supreme, or if the build did not feel as suave as it potentially would at a slightly higher price point. But before all that, here's how we tested all phones:

Running the synthetic benchmark tests was the first step in finding out each of these phones' competence on an even ground. Keeping in mind that these benchmark scores are not always the perfect reflection of how a device actually performs in real life, we went ahead with putting them through rigorous usage and performance stress tests – loading multiple applications or games at the same time, comparing them parallelly to see how one fares against the other. We put each phone through its pace in terms of regular apps, calling and messaging, network retention, gaming, audio quality, video-playing, multi-tasking, and power consumption (which also included the amount of memory each consumed for similar tasks).

Performance tests included camera tests. With an increasing amount of photography being done on smartphones, imaging quality renders were of utmost importance. The image tests we conducted were done in a number of lighting situations – dawn, daylight, overcast, studio (fluorescent), tungsten, night, low light



and flash. Image quality of the front camera played a major role, looking at the extent of usage of selfies in social media these days. Video recording tests were done out of fast moving vehicles, fast-moving objects from a stationary point, still objects and low light situations to test noise levels and frame interpolation in the recorded videos.

We then carried out the battery tests, in three ways: first, the synthetic battery

benchmark, second, our custom battery tests, and third, using it until the phones' batteries reached 0%, after normal usage since being charged to 100%. This was essential, as it gave us a complete understanding of the rating of each of the phones' batteries, alongside its real-life performance.

After putting the fundamental tests out of the way, we were left with the aspects of build, durability and design of the devices. It is interesting to note that, although design often comes secondary in the budget segment of smartphones, build quality is still given utmost importance. We put the devices through some rough usage, to see how the ergonomics, compactness, material used, buttons and overall fit. The design and resource consumption of each of the phones' interfaces were taken into account.

Within the price point of ₹13,000, we chose Asus Zenfone 2 Laser, Meizu M2 Note, Lenovo K3 Note, Yu Yureka Plus, Moto G (3rd Gen.), Intex Aqua Trend, Xiaomi Mi 4i, Honor 4X and HTC Desire 526G+ in our extensive shootout. After days of putting them through multiple tests, hours of calling, gaming, video and audio streaming, and countless photographs, here's what came out as the Best Value for money proposition, outright Best Performer and the Editor's Pick – our personal pick of the lot.